Map the Help You'd Turn to if Your Wife Ever Needed Care

Four prompts to see what you'd probably handle yourselves, sketch the kinds of help you'd want to know about in advance, write the questions to ask any service before relying on it, and name the changes that would tell you it's time to ask.

Where you are

Your wife is healthy, and so are you. A friend's family fell apart trying to find help in the week after a fall, and you've decided you'd rather know where help lives before you need it. Nothing is wrong; you just want a map.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can describe what you'd likely manage on your own, list the kinds of help you'd want to have identified ahead of time, and name a few changes that would tell you to pick up the phone.

A one-page support map with headings: What we'd probably handle ourselves, Kinds of help to identify in advance, Questions to ask before relying on any service, Changes that would tell us to ask for help, and When to look at this page again.

Before you start

- A list of the people already in your wife's life who help in small ways: friends, neighbors, your kids, her doctor's office.
- What you'd honestly manage yourself, and what you know you wouldn't.
- Any names you've heard from friends or your community of places families turn to. You don't need to have called any of them.

PROMPT 1

See what you'd probably handle yourselves

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most couples would handle more than they fear and less than they assume. Sorting it on a calm day, with no one watching, is the honest way to find out which.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes on what you already do for each other, what you're good at, and what you're not.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My wife and I are both well. I want to think ahead about what we'd handle ourselves if she ever needed care, and where we'd want help. Here is what I know about what we already do for each other, what I'm good at, and what I'm honestly not:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Here are the kinds of tasks that tend to come up: rides and appointments, paperwork and insurance, meals and the house, keeping track of what changed, talking with doctors, and being present during the day. Put each in one of three columns: WE'D PROBABLY HANDLE THIS, WE'D WANT HELP WITH THIS, and DEPENDS ON WHAT'S HAPPENING. Use only what I told you. Do not comment on her health or suggest she needs anything now.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Honest entries in the middle column; nobody is grading this.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask your wife whether she'd sort it the same way, because her answers may surprise you.

PROMPT 2

Sketch the kinds of help worth knowing about

WHY THIS MATTERS

A neighbor who drives, a church group that brings meals, a paid aide, a care consultant, and a nurse are five different kinds of help. Families get into trouble when they expect one kind to do the work of another.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your 'want help' and 'depends' columns, plus the list of people and places already around you.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my wife and I would want help with if she ever needed care, and the people and places already around us:
>
> [PASTE YOUR 'WANT HELP' AND 'DEPENDS' COLUMNS AND YOUR LIST OF PEOPLE]
>
> For each item, tell me in general terms what kind of help usually fits: family and friends, a community or faith group, paid help at home, a care consultant who coordinates, or a clinical professional. Make a table with the item, the kinds of help that fit, and a note on whether that

> help is informal support or professional care, so I don't confuse the two. Do not name any company, agency, or person, and do not tell me which to choose.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Items where only informal help is listed, since those are the ones to think harder about.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

For one item in the table, find out whether that kind of help exists in your area; just find out, don't sign up.

PROMPT 3

Write the questions to ask before relying on anyone

WHY THIS MATTERS

The plan that fails is the one built around a person who turns out to be on vacation. The same five questions, asked of a neighbor and an agency alike, keep that from happening.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The table from the second prompt.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I don't want to build our plan around someone being available who turns out not to be. Here are the kinds of help my wife and I might lean on someday:
>
> [PASTE THE TABLE FROM PROMPT 2]
>
> For each kind of help, write four or five questions we'd ask before counting on it: what exactly they do and don't do, when they're available and how fast they respond, who covers when they're away, what it costs, and how we'd stop or change it. Keep the questions the same across professional and informal help, so we ask a neighbor and an agency the same honest things. Add one line at the top saying that none of this help is real until the person or service has confirmed it. Do not assume any of them is available.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The question about who covers when they're away, which is the one that saves you in a bad week.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the questions; you'll use them the first time you actually call anyone.

PROMPT 4

Put the map on one page, with a date to look at it again

WHY THIS MATTERS

A support map is only useful if you can find it and if it is roughly current. One page, in the drawer with the other important papers, with a date on it, does both.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've gathered about how my wife and I would get help if we ever needed it:
>
> [PASTE EVERYTHING FROM PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write one page with five headings: WHAT WE'D PROBABLY HANDLE OURSELVES, KINDS OF HELP TO IDENTIFY IN ADVANCE, QUESTIONS TO ASK BEFORE RELYING ON ANY SERVICE, CHANGES THAT WOULD TELL US TO ASK FOR HELP, and WHEN TO LOOK AT THIS PAGE AGAIN. Under the fourth heading, list changes in her, in me, and in the people around us that would make us pick up the phone, in plain words, with a separate line that anything urgent goes to emergency services or her doctor. Under the last, suggest a yearly date. Mark the top 'planning copy, nothing is arranged.' Do not recommend a service or write a care plan.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page you'd actually be glad to find in a drawer on a bad day.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Put the page with your other important papers, tell your wife where it is, and put the date in your calendar.

A map is better with the territory filled in.

The care interview gathers your wife's situation, her doctors, papers, people, and routines, into a Family Care Profile. It isn't a care plan. It's the file you'd want to already have on the day you reach for the support map.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›